

PLATANUS
Plane

PLATANACEAE

Genus of deciduous trees, grown for their imposing habit, foliage, and flaking bark. Flowers are inconspicuous. Spherical fruit clusters hang from shoots in fall. Fully hardy to frost hardy. Requires full sun and deep, fertile, well-drained soil. Propagate species by seed in fall, *P. x hispanica* by hardwood cuttings in early winter. All except *P. orientalis* are susceptible to the fungal disease plane anthracnose. ☉ Contact with the basal tufts of hair on the fruits may irritate the skin and respiratory system. ***P. x acerifolia***. See *P. x hispanica*. ***P. x hispanica***, syn. *P. x acerifolia* (London plane), illus. p.63. ***P. orientalis*** (Oriental plane) illus. p.63. ***f. digitata*** (syn. ‘Laciniata’) is a vigorous, spreading tree. H and S 100ft (30m) or more. Has flaking, gray, brown, and cream bark and glossy green leaves deeply divided into 3–5, sometimes slightly toothed, fingerlike lobes. Clusters of fruits persist into fall and winter. **‘Laciniata’** see *P.o. f. digita*. H6

PLATYCARYA
JUGLANDACEAE

Genus of deciduous, large shrubs or trees, grown for their foliage, which turns yellow in fall, their catkins, and their long-lasting conelike, racemes of fruit. Fully hardy. Requires full sun and fertile, well-drained soil. Propagate by seed in fall. ***P. strobilacea***. Deciduous, spreading tree. H and S 50ft (15m). Has ashlike, bright green leaves with 7–15 leaflets. Upright, green catkins are borne from mid- to late summer; males are slender and cylindrical, often drooping at tips, females are conelike, turn brown and persist through winter. Z6–9

PLATYCERIUM
Staghorn fern
POLYPODIACEAE

Genus of evergreen, epiphytic ferns, best grown in hanging baskets or fastened to and suspended from pieces of wood. Produces 2 kinds of fronds: permanent, broad, sterile “nest leaves” forming the main part of the plant; and strap-shaped, arching fertile fronds, often partly divided into two. Frost tender. Thrives in warm, humid, partial shaded conditions; needs fibrous, peaty compost with hardly any soil. Propagate by detaching buds in spring or summer and planting in compost, or by spores in summer or early fall. ***P. alcornoe*** of gardens. See *P. bifurcatum*. ***P. bifurcatum***, syn. *P. alcornoe* of gardens (Common staghorn fern), illus. p.479. ***P. superbum*** (Giant staghorn fern). Epiphytic fern. H 6ft (2m), S 5ft (1.5).Long, grayish-green, sterile fronds, to 6ft (2m), are rounded to kidney-shaped, with deeply lobed upper margins. Leathery, bright green, fertile fronds fork into strap-shaped segments; a large, round patch of spores forms between the 2 main forks. Z11–12 (min. 50°F/10°C)

PLATYCLADUS
Oriental thuja
CUPRESSACEAE

☉ Contact with the foliage may aggravate skin allergies. See also CONIFERS. ***P. orientalis***, syn. *Biota orientalis*, *Thuja orientalis*. Conifer with an irregularly rounded crown. H to 50ft (15m), S to 20ft (6m). Has fibrous bark and flattened, vertical sprays of scalelike, scentless, mid- or yellow-green leaves. Egg-shaped cones are glaucous gray. Z6–9. **‘Aurea Nana’** (illus. p.105), H and S 3ft (90cm), is a dwarf cultivar with yellow-green foliage that turns bronze in winter. **‘Franky Boy’**, H 6ft (2m), S 4ft (1.2m), is shrubby with upswept growth and threadlike, golden foliage that turns pale green in summer and bronzed in winter. **‘Semperaurea’**, H 10ft (3m), S 6ft (2m), is compact, with golden leaves.

PLATYCODON
Balloon flower
CAMPANULACEAE

Genus of one species of perennial, grown for its flowers in summer. Fully hardy. Needs sun and light, sandy soil. Propagate by basal cuttings of non-flowering shoots in summer, with a bit of root attached, or by seed in fall. ***P. grandiflorus*** illus. p.269. **Apoyama Group** are dwarf, clump-forming perennials. H 8in (20cm), S 1ft (30cm). Have ovate, sharply toothed, bluish-green leaves. In late summer, clusters of large, balloonlike flower buds at stem tips open into bell-shaped, blue, purple, violet, or white flowers. **‘Mariesii’**, H and S 1½ft (45cm), produces blue or purplish-blue flowers. Z3–8

PLATYSTEMON
PAPAVERACEAE

Genus of one species of very variable, summer-flowering annual. Fully hardy. Grow in sun and in fertile, well-drained soil. Propagate by seed sown outdoors in spring or early fall. ***P. californicus*** (Cream cups) illus. p.321.

PLECTRANTHUS
LAMIACEAE/LABIATAE

Genus of annuals, evergreen, trailing, or bushy perennials, semisucculents, and shrubs, grown for their foliage. Frost tender. Easy to grow if kept moist in partial shade or bright light. Cut back stem tips in growing season if plants become too straggly. Propagate by stem cuttings or division in spring or summer. ***P. australis*** of gardens. See *P. verticillatus*. ***P. coleoides*** **‘Variegatus’** of gardens. See *P. madagascariensis* ‘Variegated Mintleaf’. ***P. forsteri*** **‘Marginatus’** illus. p.298. ***P. fruticosus*** **‘James’** illus. p.454. ***P. madagascariensis*** (Mintleaf). Creeping, shrubby perennial. H 1ft (30cm), S indefinite. Has rounded, scalloped, fleshy leaves. Bears 2-lipped, lavender-blue or white flowers, often dotted with red. Z10–12 (min. 45°F/7°C). **‘Variegated Mintleaf’** (syn. *P. coleoides* ‘Variegatus’

of gardens) has white-variegated leaves. ***P. oertendahlil*** (Candle plant, Swedish ivy). Evergreen, prostrate perennial. H to 8in (20cm), trailing to 3ft (1m) or more. Rounded, scalloped, dark green leaves are reddish-green below, with white veins above. Has racemes of tubular, white or pale mauve flowers at irregular intervals throughout the year. Z10–12 (min. 45°F/7°C) ***P. scutellarioides***. See *Solenostemon scutellarioides*. ***P. thyrsoides***, syn. *Coleus thyrsoides*, *Solenostemon thyrsoides*. Fast-growing, bushy perennial, often grown as an annual. H to 3ft (1m), S 2ft (60cm). Has heart-shaped, serrated, mid-green leaves. Spikes of tubular, bright blue flowers are borne at various times of year. Z10–11 (min. 39°F/4°C) ***P. verticillatus***, syn. *P. australis* of gardens (Swedish ivy). Evergreen, trailing perennial with square stems. H to 6in (15cm), S indefinite. Has rounded, waxy, glossy, green leaves with scalloped edges. Racemes of tubular, white or pale mauve flowers are produced intermittently through the year. Z10–11

PLEIOBLASTUS
POACEAE/GRAMINEAE

See also GRASSES, BAMBOOS, RUSHES, and SEDGES. ***P. variegatus***, syn. *Arundinaria fortunei*, *A. variegata* (Dwarf white-stripe bamboo), illus. p.284. ***P. viridistriatus***, syn. *Arundinaria auricoma*, illus. p.289.

PLEIONE
ORCHIDACEAE

See also ORCHIDS. ***P. bulbocodioides*** (illus. p.466). Deciduous, terrestrial orchid. H 6in (15cm). In spring, usually before a solitary leaf develops, bears pink, rose or magenta flowers, 2–5in (5–12cm) across, with darker purple marks on lips. Leaf is narrowly lance-shaped, 5½in (14cm) long. Often difficult to flower: regular feeding helps to increase pseudobulbs to flowering size. Z10–11 ***P. x confusa***. Deciduous, terrestrial orchid. H 6in (15cm). Bears canary-yellow flowers, 2–3in (5–8cm) across, with brown or purple blotches on lips, singly in spring before foliage emerges. Has lance-shaped leaves, 4–7in (10–18cm) long. Does best in an alpine house. Needs partial shade. Z10–11 ***P. hookeriana***. Deciduous, terrestrial orchid. H 3–6in (8–15cm). Lilac-pink, rose or white flowers, 2–3in (5–7cm) across, each with a brown- or purplish-spotted lip, are borne singly in spring with lance-shaped leaves, 2–8in (5–20cm) long. Cultivate as for *P. x confusa*. Z10–11 ***P. humilis***. Deciduous, epiphytic or rock-dwelling orchid. H 6in (15cm). In winter, before foliage emerges, white flowers, 3–3½in (7–9cm) across, each with a crimson-spotted lip, are borne singly or in pairs. Lance-shaped leaves are 7–10in (18–25cm) long. Grow as for *P. x confusa*. Z10–11 ***P. praecox***. Deciduous, epiphytic or rock-dwelling orchid. H 6in (15cm). Flowers, to 3in (8cm) across, are borne in pairs in fall, after foliage. They are white to rose-purple,

PLUMERIA

with violet marks. Leaves are oblong to lance-shaped and 6–10in (15–25cm) long. Grow as for *P. x confusa*. Z10–11

PLEIOSPILOS
Living rock
AIZOACEAE

Genus of solitary or clump-forming, perennial succulents with almost stemless rosettes bearing up to 4 pairs of fleshy, erect leaves, like pieces of granite, each with a flat upper surface and each pair united at the base. Flowers are daisylike. Individual species are very similar, and many are difficult to identify. Frost tender. Needs sun and well-drained soil. Propagate by seed or by division in spring or summer. ***P. bolusii*** illus. p.495. ***P. compactus*** illus. p.495.

PLUMBAGO
PLUMBAGINACEAE

Genus of annuals, perennials, and evergreen shrubs and woody-stemmed, scrambling climbers, grown for their primrose-shaped flowers. Half hardy to frost tender. Grow in full light or partial shade, in fertile, well-drained soil. Water regularly, less when not in full growth. Tie stems to supports. Thin out or spur back all previous year’s growth in early spring. Propagate by semiripe cuttings in summer. Whitefly may be a problem. ***P. auriculata***, syn. *P. capensis* (Cape leadwort), illus. p.205. ***P. capensis***. See *P. auriculata*. ***P. indica***, syn. *P. rosea*. Evergreen, spreading shrub or semiclimber. H 6ft (2m), S 3ft (1m). Leaves are ovate to elliptic and mid-green. Has terminal racemes of primrose-shaped, red or pink flowers, 1in (2.5cm) long. These are produced in summer, if hard-pruned annually in spring, or from late winter onward, if left unpruned and trained as a climber. Z10–12 (min. 45°F/7°C) ***P. rosea***. See *P. indica*.

PLUMERIA
Frangipani, Pagoda tree
APOCYNACEAE

Genus of mainly deciduous, fleshy-branched shrubs and trees, grown for their flowers in summer–fall. Frost tender. Requires full sun and freely draining soil. Water container specimens moderately while in growth, keep dry in winter when leafless. Stem tips may be cut out to induce branching. Propagate by seed or by leafless stem-tip cuttings in late spring. Red spider mite may be a nuisance. ☉ The milky sap may cause mild stomach upset if ingested. ***P. acuminata***. See *P. rubra* f. *acutifolia*. ***P. acutifolia***. See *P. rubra* f. *acutifolia*. ***P. rubra*** illus. p.453. ***f. acutifolia*** (syn. *P. acuminata*, *P. acutifolia*) is a deciduous, spreading, sparsely branched small tree or shrub. H and S 12ft (4m) or more. Lance-shaped to ovate leaves are 8–12in (20–30cm) long. Bears fragrant, yellow-eyed, white flowers, with 5 spreading petals, from summer to fall. Z11–12 (min. 50–55°F/10–13°C).